

COMPLETE NARRATIVE EDITION

Print and separate before play.

This complete edition contains 44 PDF pages. The ranges below are **physical PDF positions**, not the archive folios retained within the case.

Player packet: PDF positions 3-31 (29 pages).

Optional hints: PDF positions 33-36 (4 pages).

Sealed solution: PDF positions 37-44 (8 pages).

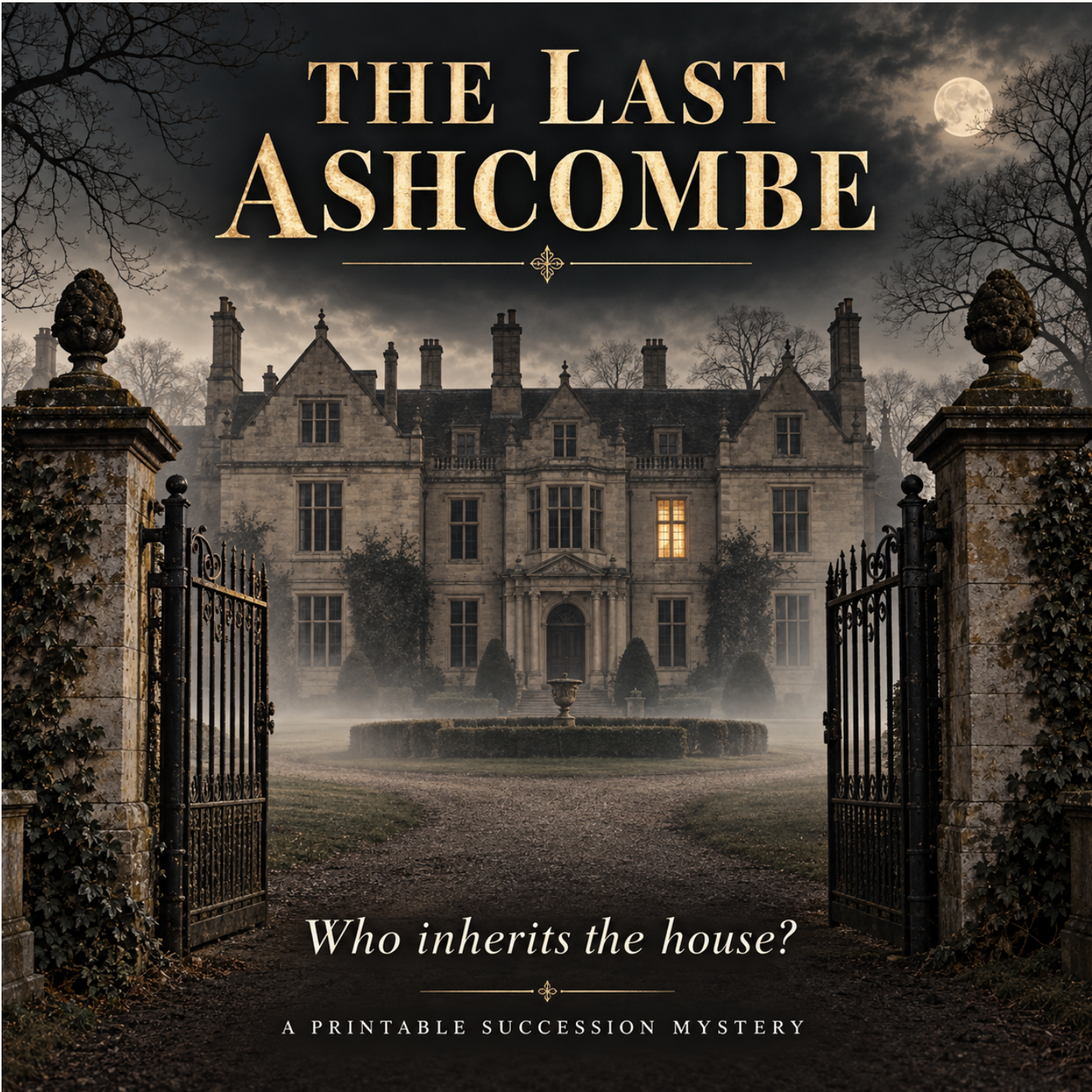
For the simplest setup, print the separate Player, Hints, and Sealed Solution PDFs. If using this file, separate the protected sections using these ranges before distributing the player packet. The sections start on fresh duplex sheets.

Print US Letter at 100%, or A4 with Fit; grayscale is sufficient. Read the player instructions for the archive folios, story leaves, and investigation. All characters and records are fictional.

PRINT SETUP

The player file begins next.

Keep the hints and solution separate before anyone starts reading. This reverse protects the first player sheet when printing duplex.



THE LAST ASHCOMBE



Who inherits the house?



A PRINTABLE SUCCESSION MYSTERY

The player dossier

16 exhibits / a family to reconstruct / one rightful heir

Read the rules. Follow the records. Prove the claim.

READ FIRST

Read the people. Test the papers.

Print the Player PDF in full. This edition contains 29 pages, including its cover and interleaved story. Use US Letter, portrait, actual size / 100%; on A4, use Fit. Grayscale is sufficient. Single-sided lets you spread the records out; duplex uses the long edge. Keep the separate hints and sealed solution away from the player stack.

Follow the printed archive folios. Existing page references mean the numbers labeled ARCHIVE in the footers, which remain stable. New story leaves use S0-S3. They make the PDF positions different from the archive numbers. Use the bookmarks or clickable catalog to find a page on screen.

Begin with the opening scene and brief. Read E01-E03 and choose your next record through archive folio 4. Each later scene names the records to read first. In a nonlinear search, return to that scene after you have examined its records; scene order does not prove a connection.

Let the records carry the proof. The new scenes dramatize the people around these papers. They are fictional narrative, not additional archival exhibits. A character can be mistaken. Names, dates, parents, addresses, source references, and the supplied rules establish the case; sympathy does not.

Make your case. Use archive folios 22-25. Cite exhibit codes and exact fields, test alternatives, and leave unsupported matters open. Everyone investigates; no host, internet, cutting, or outside research is required. Use hints only when needed; open the solution after answering all final questions.

Apply the fictional settlement, not external inheritance law. Determine entitlement at 6:15 a.m. on 20 September 1913. Petitioners are not an exhaustive candidate set.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The house waiting

Before the opening brief

The house had been locked for six days, but people still spoke as though one of them already owned the silence inside it.

Lawrence stood nearest Harcourt's desk. He referred to the place as ours, then corrected himself to the family property. Celia noticed the correction because she had spent a lifetime hearing the first phrase and being expected to understand that it did not quite include her.

"There is no need for everyone to be kept waiting," Lawrence said.

Harcourt arranged the petitions in the order received. "Then we should begin with the settlement."

"We know what our grandfather intended."

"We have what he wrote."

Peter Vale smiled at that. Celia saw it and wondered how long his pleasure in careful wording would last if the words troubled his own claim.

She had brought a petition too. Putting her name on it had felt more exposed than she expected. She did not pretend Lawrence's place in the family could be wished away. She wanted her own place recorded correctly, and she wanted the rules read before confidence hardened into possession.

"You might at least trust me to see you properly provided for," Lawrence told her.

"I am asking you to let the papers be read."

He looked hurt. She knew that hurt could be sincere and still make it harder for her to insist. Since Edward's death, people had been particularly ready to offer advice in the shape of decisions already taken for her.

Peter laid his hand on his petition. "There is an elder branch."

Harcourt did not move the keys toward him. "Then we will follow it."

Celia looked through the window at the house. Somewhere in its everyday arrangements were people who had to turn up for work regardless of which claimant won. A settlement might transfer property at an exact instant. The people depending on that property would have to live through everything that followed.

She drew her chair close enough to read. The task was not to choose the most persuasive person in the room. It was to establish who belonged in the line, where that person stood, and who was alive when Julian died. Celia intended to listen even when the answer ceased to help her.

A letter from the trustees

Ashcombe House has been locked for six days. Three petitions lie on my desk. Each petitioner can explain, at length, why somebody else ought not to have the keys.

M. Harcourt, clerk to the settlement trustees

Julian Ashcombe died at 6:15 on the morning of Saturday, 20 September. He never married and left no children. He occupied the estate as the first life holder appointed in his father Gideon's settlement. The settlement now requires its first succession by descent.

Lawrence Ashcombe insists that the name on the gate settles the matter. Peter Vale says the older family branch comes first and that its last rival died in infancy. Celia Marsh has asked that the trustees examine the actual wording before accepting either account.

An earlier genealogical memorandum has been used as though it were a final certificate. It is enclosed with the documents from which it was compiled. I have also obtained household and service records where names changed. Their relevance is for you to decide.

The trustees require a written determination for the instant of Julian's death. Do not assume that one of the petitioners must be the successor. A person need not have submitted a petition to qualify.

Your commission

Identify the rightful successor. Reconstruct the qualifying line from Gideon. Deal expressly with Peter Vale's and Lawrence Ashcombe's claims. Explain any earlier person you bypass. State which two people would follow your selected successor in the order, using the same cutoff facts and setting aside only the people already selected.

That final ranking exercise is a check on your reading of the settlement, not a request to calculate any future inheritance.

Return the evidence with your determination. The house will wait for a name that can be proved.

M. Harcourt

The archive index

Start with E01-E03. Then choose which claim or uncertainty to test. The words below describe the files, not their conclusions.

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Working pages: family tree 22 / claim ledger 23 / determination 24 / continuation 25.
The separate hint and solution files are optional until you have completed your answer.

The Ashcombe Settlement

Certified operative extract, register AS/1880/14. Settlor: **Gideon Ashcombe**. Appointed first life holder: **Julian Ashcombe**. Interest: the house, grounds and settlement fund as one indivisible estate.

R1 / What passes, and when

The house, grounds and settlement fund called the Ashcombe Estate pass together to one person at the death of Julian Ashcombe, the first life holder appointed by this settlement. Determine the successor at that instant, not at the later date of this inquiry. Julian has no power to appoint a substitute.

R2 / Who may succeed

Consider the descendants of Gideon Ashcombe through the parent-child relationships established in the certified birth and family records. Gideon himself and the outgoing holder are not candidates. A spouse or step-parent gains no descent relationship merely through marriage or a household description. No condition of sex, surname, occupation, wealth or marriage applies.

R3 / The order of the branches

Begin with Gideon's eldest child. Consider that child before their children. Then work through that child's descendants in the same way, taking each sibling in birth order and completing that sibling's branch before proceeding to the next. Only after the whole elder branch has been considered may the next child of Gideon, and that child's descendants, be considered.

R4 / Death and representation

A person must be alive at the succession instant to receive the estate. Bypass a person who died before that instant, but continue through their descendants in the place that person's branch already holds. Being closer in generations to Gideon does not move a person ahead of an elder branch.

Clauses R5-R8 continue on the next page. The appointment of Julian as first life holder does not establish branch priority for the succession after his death.

The settlement, continued

R5 / Personal relinquishment

A signed personal relinquishment entered in the settlement register before the succession instant prevents its signer from receiving the estate. It does not surrender, accelerate or extinguish the rights of that signer's descendants. Continue through the descendants before leaving that branch.

R6 / Names and proof

Follow the same person across a change of surname when the records support the identity. A name in an index, an assertion in a petition or a relationship-to-head entry alone does not establish parentage or identify a death. Use the underlying particulars and corroborating records.

R7 / The limits of this inquiry

The certified return E16 exhausts the relevant descendant branches and personal relinquishments at the succession instant. Accept its stated scope and certified facts. It does not decide any identity, survival or priority question that it expressly leaves to the exhibits. There are no missing wills, amendments, private disqualifications or undisclosed branches outside this packet.

R8 / The determination

Select the first living, non-relinquishing person reached in the prescribed order. Explain that person's qualifying descent and resolve every superior claim. If a material fact remains unproved, record the unresolved question rather than inventing a fact. Later succession following the selected person's death is outside this inquiry.

Certificate of M. Harcourt, 26 September 1913: the foregoing eight clauses are the complete rules needed for this determination. The instrument is valid and unamended within this fictional case. No other instrument overrides it.

The founder's family register

Extract from the Ashcombe family register, checked against the settlement birth and death returns. Certified 23 September 1913.

Founder	Gideon Ashcombe / 14 May 1808 - 11 January 1881
Spouse	Margaret Ashcombe, formerly Wren / 2 March 1810 - 7 July 1872
Marriage	9 June 1830 / St Anne's, Mere Vale

Child	Birth	Death
Frances Ashcombe	18 February 1832	4 October 1899
Matthew Ashcombe	9 August 1835	16 April 1905
Julian Ashcombe	21 November 1841	20 September 1913, 6:15 a.m.

Matthew's family

Marriage: Matthew Ashcombe and Violet Grant, 12 May 1861. Their children were Lawrence Ashcombe, born 3 December 1863, and Celia Ashcombe, born 14 June 1868. Celia married Edward Marsh on 6 April 1892; Edward died on 8 February 1908. The return records no other children of Matthew.

Julian's entry

Unmarried. No children. The appointed first life holder under AS/1880/14.

Cross-reference

Frances's married household appears in the Bell records. The family register does not itself determine any present entitlement.

| *Extract compared and signed: M. Harcourt / 23 September 1913.*

The three petitions

Lawrence Ashcombe / received 22 September

My father Matthew was Gideon's elder son. I am Matthew's elder child and the only living petitioner who bears the Ashcombe name. I have always understood that the estate must remain with a man of that name. I request possession of the house.

Lawrence Ashcombe

Peter Vale / received 23 September

My grandmother Frances was born before Matthew. Her son Robert died in 1904, and his only child Ada Bell appears in the 1889 death index. My mother Alice filed her personal relinquishment in 1902. As her only child, I claim the place that follows. I rely upon the Bell memorandum in the trustees' old file.

Peter Vale

Celia Marsh / received 24 September

I am Matthew's younger child. I do not concede that being a daughter excludes me. My brother may stand before me, but I ask that the trustees record my place and examine the Bell papers before treating a surname as an answer.

Celia Marsh

Clerk's receipt note: each petitioner appeared in person on the date recorded. These are claims by interested parties. Their assertions about other people have not been certified by receipt of the petitions.

THE STORY CONTINUES

Being right about someone else

After E01-E03

Peter read the branch rule aloud. He sounded pleased with the settlement's refusal to reward the familiar surname merely for being familiar.

Lawrence interrupted. "The name has meant something to this house."

"The rule gives no preference for it," Peter said.

He was right about the wording. Celia could see how satisfying he found it to be right in front of Lawrence. She could also see Harcourt waiting until he finished before asking what established the rest of Peter's position.

Peter brought forward the references he relied on. His account had a path through the family, a death, a supposed ended line, a relinquishment. It sounded orderly. Harcourt treated each part as a separate claim to check.

"My mother signed," Peter said.

"We will read what she signed."

Lawrence began to object, then stopped. For a moment both men wanted the same thing: for one reassuring piece of family knowledge to be accepted without another trip through the files.

Celia asked to see the relinquishment with the settlement beside it. Peter gave her the copy. His expression suggested that sharing it ought to make her grateful to him. She thanked him for the paper, not for the conclusion.

"If it removes her," she asked Harcourt, "we still have to read what it says about those after her?"

"We have to read all of it."

Celia could not make herself uninterested in the result. She might lose by the same rule she insisted was worth following. That did not make the rule an insult to her.

Beyond the desk, a door opened and closed as the house's work continued. The petitioners' names were on the papers because they had petitioned. The settlement did not say that a person became a descendant only by entering this room and asking to be counted.

Harcourt set out the branch registers. Peter had challenged one easy assumption. Whether he had built his own claim on another was still a question for the records.

Frances leaves the family name

Marriage register / entry M-203

Date and place	12 October 1853 / St Anne's, Mere Vale
Bride	Frances Ashcombe / 21 / spinster
Bride's father	Gideon Ashcombe / landowner
Bridegroom	Nathan Bell / 24 / bachelor / joiner
Witnesses	Margaret Ashcombe; Matthew Ashcombe

Household return / 7 April 1861

4 Mill Lane, Millford. Selected columns transcribed from the household return.

Name	Relation	Age	Occupation
Nathan Bell	Head	32	Joiner
Frances Bell	Wife	29	-
Robert Bell	Son	6	Scholar
Alice Bell	Daughter	3	-

All four persons are recorded as born in Mere Vale or Millford. A household relation is a record claim; use the birth extracts where a qualifying parent-child relationship matters.

| *Certified extracts supplied together under file BELL/53-61.*

Two children in the Bell branch

Entry B-112 / 1855

Child	Robert Bell
Birth	14 January 1855 / 4 Mill Lane, Millford
Father	Nathan Bell / joiner
Mother	Frances Bell, formerly Ashcombe
Informant	Frances Bell, mother / 4 Mill Lane
Registered	21 January 1855

Entry B-287 / 1858

Child	Alice Bell
Birth	2 March 1858 / 4 Mill Lane, Millford
Father	Nathan Bell / joiner
Mother	Frances Bell, formerly Ashcombe
Informant	Nathan Bell, father / 4 Mill Lane
Registered	9 March 1858

Registrar's certification: these extracts reproduce the parentage and birth particulars of the two entries. The extent of each branch is addressed separately in E16.

A death at Mill Lane

Date and place	11 February 1904 / 4 Mill Lane, Millford
Name	Robert Bell
Age	49 years
Occupation	Joiner
Cause	Pneumonia
Informant	Edith Bell, widow of deceased, present at the death
Informant's address	4 Mill Lane, Millford
Registered	12 February 1904

Attached settlement identity docket

The deceased was Robert Bell born 14 January 1855, son of Nathan Bell and Frances formerly Ashcombe. Marriage entry M-518 records his marriage to Edith Lane on 18 June 1886. The docket was attached by the settlement clerk on receipt of the certificate in 1904.

This certificate records Robert's death. It does not certify the death of any child or the extinction of his branch.

| *Received for settlement records / 17 February 1904*

The Vale connection

Marriage / entry M-421

Date and place	10 July 1880 / St Anne's, Mere Vale
Bride	Alice Bell / 22 / spinster
Bride's father	Nathan Bell / joiner
Bridegroom	Henry Vale / 26 / bachelor / schoolmaster
Witnesses	Robert Bell; Frances Bell

Birth / entry B-706

Child	Peter Vale
Birth	17 May 1882 / School House, Mere Vale
Father	Henry Vale / schoolmaster
Mother	Alice Vale, formerly Bell
Informant	Alice Vale, mother
Registered	24 May 1882

Supporting identity note: the bride in M-421 is Alice Bell born 2 March 1858, whose parents are recorded in E05. The same Alice is the mother recorded in B-706.

A personal relinquishment

I, Alice Vale, formerly Bell, release for myself the right to receive the Ashcombe Estate when the settlement next takes effect by descent.

I request that this instrument be entered as a **personal relinquishment** under the settlement. I make no surrender for my son or for any other descendant. Nothing in this instrument represents that my brother Robert's family has ended.

Signatory	Alice Vale / born Alice Bell, 2 March 1858
Executed	3 March 1902
Witnesses	Henry Vale; M. Harcourt
Entered in register	4 March 1902 / AS-R/02/1

Receipt endorsed by the trustees

Accepted and registered under clause R5. No payment, surname condition or additional exclusion is attached to this instrument.

Alice Vale

A separate status declaration in E16 addresses whether Alice was living at the succession instant.

The old Bell memorandum

Papers of B. Seddon, former clerk to the settlement. Pencil heading reproduced below.

| *PROVISIONAL - full particulars still to be obtained*

Robert Bell, son of Frances, died 1904. His only child was Ada Bell, believed born in 1888. The index below appears to record her death. On that assumption the Robert Bell line has ended, leaving the Alice Vale line to be examined.

Copied death-index line

Name	Age	Year	Entry
Ada Bell	1	1889	D-447

The index gives no parent's name. Request full entry D-447 before certifying the line extinct. Check Robert's child against birth entry B-903. Return not completed.

Later filing note / 1913

This memorandum was enclosed with Peter Vale's petition by request. No final extinction certificate by Seddon is present. The underlying entries have now been supplied in this packet.

| *B.S. / comparison outstanding*

The child of Robert and Edith

Date and place of birth	5 March 1888 / 4 Mill Lane, Millford
Name	Ada
Father	Robert Bell
Mother	Edith Bell, formerly Lane
Father's occupation	Joiner
Informant	Edith Bell, mother / 4 Mill Lane, Millford
Date of registration	12 March 1888
Child's registered surname	Bell

Record supplied

A certified full extract of B-903, supplied 24 September 1913. The father and mother named in this entry are the Robert and Edith whose marriage and death particulars are attached to E06.

| *Compared with the register / A. Fenwick, registrar*

The date, place, parent names and mother's former surname are available for comparison with later records.

The full entry behind the index

Date and place of death	29 November 1889 / 9 Harbour Street, Bracken
Name	Ada Bell
Age	1 year
Description	Daughter of Walter Bell, dock labourer
Cause	Measles
Informant	Jane Bell, mother, present at the death
Informant's address	9 Harbour Street, Bracken
Date of registration	30 November 1889

Registrar's identity comparison

The birth entry associated with this death is B-891: Ada Bell, born 12 February 1888 at 9 Harbour Street; father Walter Bell; mother Jane Bell, formerly Pike. These particulars identify the child in D-447.

This is the full D-447 entry cited in the working note. The short index and this extract refer to the same death.

| *Certified full extract / 24 September 1913*

THE STORY CONTINUES

A note that became a certainty

After E04-E11

The word provisional was easy to read once Celia looked directly at it. She wondered how many times the note had been discussed without anyone pronouncing that word aloud.

Peter stared at the reference beneath it.

"It was in the papers," he said.

Harcourt did not dispute that. "So is the instruction to obtain the full record."

"I thought that had been done."

The room was quiet long enough for Celia to feel the temptation to enjoy his discomfort. He had enjoyed Lawrence's. There would be a certain symmetry to it. It would not help identify either child.

She moved the two certificates so their parents and addresses could be compared.

"Then we can do it now."

Peter looked at her as if he had expected an accusation. She had one available, but not one the evidence yet justified. Relying on a mistaken note could be careless, self-serving, or deliberately dishonest. His claim register and the unfinished memorandum did not alone tell them which private explanation was true.

The full entries did have exact things to offer: a birth date, parents, a place, a source number. A child had died. Another child had been recorded as born. The similarity of their names had made it easy for one small life to be used to close another's line.

Lawrence leaned forward. "So his claim fails?"

Harcourt left his pen down. "We have not finished tracing the family."

Celia almost laughed, without pleasure. Each man could recognize the danger of a shortcut when it belonged to the other.

She thought of Alice's relinquishment, a signed act with a limited effect. People kept wanting papers to do more than their words did: turn a person's withdrawal into a branch's extinction, turn an index resemblance into a certified death, turn a trusted surname into a rule.

The next records would have to carry the identity forward. If the assumption was wrong, there might be someone to find. Celia felt the question change. It was no longer only where she herself stood. It was whether another person had been left waiting outside a conclusion nobody had properly checked.

Service file number 27

Original engagement / 1 May 1905

Employee number	27
Name engaged	Ada Bell
Date and place of birth	5 March 1888 / Millford
Parent or next of kin	Edith Bell, formerly Lane / 4 Mill Lane
Late father	Robert Bell / joiner
Post	Linen-room assistant
Signature entered	Ada Bell

Name entered for payroll / 6 August 1907

Following my mother's marriage to Samuel Finch, please enter my wages as Ada Finch. I remain the employee entered above as Ada Bell. My date of birth is unchanged.

Ada Bell / to be entered Ada Finch

Countersigned: Edith Finch, formerly Edith Bell and born Lane. Examined and approved: Mrs Agnes Pike, housekeeper. Employee number **27** retained.

Service-file note

Change of name for correspondence and wages only. The marriage certificate supplied with the request is filed among the household papers. This entry makes no claim of altered parentage.

Edith marries again

Date and place	3 August 1907 / Mere Vale Register Office
Bride	Edith Bell / 41 / widow
Residence	4 Mill Lane, Millford
Bride's father	Thomas Lane / mill worker
Bridegroom	Samuel Finch / 43 / widower / gardener
Bridegroom's residence	Elm Cottage, Mere Vale
Witnesses	Ada Bell; Agnes Pike

Supporting identity declaration

Edith declares that she was born Edith Lane, married Robert Bell on 18 June 1886, and was widowed on his death on 11 February 1904. The registration clerk compared the entries named in her declaration.

A certified copy was received by the Ashcombe housekeeper on 6 August 1907 with a request to amend the wage book.

| *A. Fenwick, registrar / 3 August 1907*

A daughter in another household

Address: Elm Cottage, Mere Vale. Schedule 84. Selected columns from the household's completed return.

Name	Relation to head	Age	Condition	Occupation
Samuel Finch	Head	47	Married	Gardener
Edith Finch	Wife	44	Married	-
Ada Finch	Daughter	23	Single	Linen-room assistant

Marriage particulars / Edith Finch

Completed years of present marriage	Children born alive to present marriage	Still living	Died
3	0	0	0

Birthplaces entered: Samuel, Mere Vale; Edith, Millford; Ada, Millford. The form was signed Samuel Finch.

How to read these columns

The children counts concern the wife's **present marriage**. They do not count every child she may have had before that marriage. The relation column reports a household relationship to the head; by itself it does not establish biological parentage.

This fictional extract uses selected kinds of fields found in 1911 census schedules. No outside census knowledge is needed to interpret the case.

The morning the house fell silent

Ashcombe House / Saturday, 20 September 1913

Employee	Name in book	Duty recorded
27	Ada Finch	Linen room / 6:00 a.m.-12:30 p.m.
11	Agnes Pike	Housekeeper / morning duty

At 6:15 this morning, when Mr Harcourt came from Mr Ashcombe's room with the news, Ada Finch, employee 27, was with me at the linen-room table. I saw her enter at six and she remained on the morning duty.

Agnes Pike / signed 20 September 1913

Wage-book receipt / 27 September 1913

Employee	27
Name	Ada Finch
Service period	20-26 September 1913
Receipt	Received in person / Ada Finch
Witness	Agnes Pike

Clerk's note: the employee identifier is the continuing identifier of the service file. This book records attendance and payment, not inheritance rights.

The certified extent of the family

For the succession instant of 20 September 1913, the trustees certify the following branch counts after examination of the family returns. Counts are lifetime children born by that instant, including children who later died. They are not counts of living heirs.

Parent or recorded couple	Children / scope
Gideon and Margaret Ashcombe	3 / all listed in E02
Frances Ashcombe, later Bell	2 / both identified in E05
Matthew Ashcombe	2 / both listed in E02
Julian Ashcombe	0
Robert Bell and Edith formerly Lane	1 / the child of B-903
Alice Bell, later Vale	1 / the child of B-706
Edith and Samuel Finch, together	0
Lawrence Ashcombe; Celia Marsh; Peter Vale	0 each
The child of B-903	0

These returns exhaust Gideon's descendant branches and their children at the cutoff. No named descendant has additional children outside the recorded relationships.

Status and registered instruments

Alice Vale, Peter Vale, Lawrence Ashcombe and Celia Marsh were each living at 6:15 a.m. on 20 September 1913. E08 is the sole personal relinquishment registered for any of Gideon's descendants; no other exclusion applies. Earlier deaths are certified in E02 and E06.

The return does **not** decide whether the child in B-903 is the child in D-447, or establish the child's later name or survival. Those questions must be resolved from the supplied exhibits.

| *M. Harcourt / certificate accepted under R7*

THE STORY CONTINUES

The name on the wage line

After E12-E16

Ada Finch knew how a wage line could make a person seem smaller than the work she did. Employee 27. Name. Period. Amount. Signature. There was nothing improper about those columns. She depended on their being accurate.

It was the way people sometimes read them that troubled her, as if being entered under service meant she could appear nowhere else.

Harcourt asked her to look at the copies. Agnes Pike stayed nearby. Ada was grateful for a familiar person who did not fill every pause with an explanation of what she ought to feel.

"This is about the name?" Ada asked.

"It is about connecting the records correctly."

Her mother's marriage, her former surname, the request to change the payroll entry: ordinary arrangements returned to her as things strangers needed to examine. She had signed because the entry concerned her. She had not been writing a clue for someone else's inheritance dispute.

"You can ask me a question," she said. "You needn't discuss it over me."

Harcourt turned his chair toward her. "You're right."

It was a small correction, but Agnes watched him make it.

The duty record contained the exact time the settlement required. Ada remembered the work of that morning more readily than the significance other people now attached to the clock. Julian's death had been news carried into a room where people were already at work. For the claimants it had become an instant on which everything turned.

Celia stood at the doorway until Ada looked toward her. She did not offer congratulations, sympathy, or a prediction. None would have been fair before the line was established.

"They should get your name right," she said.

Ada studied her. "Yes. They should."

The register of branch bounds still had to be read with the earlier certificates. Identity was not, by itself, priority. Survival was not, by itself, entitlement. Harcourt gathered the copies so each link could be tested under the stated rules.

Ada asked for the papers to be explained to her when that work was done. She was accustomed to receiving instructions. This was a request to be included in the answer.

Reconstruct the family

Place Gideon at the top. Work through his children in birth order. Add the next generations, former surnames, birth/death dates and exhibit references. Mark a death or personal relinquishment on the individual; decide separately what happens to the branch.

Gideon Ashcombe

Relationships or identities still to prove:

Test the competing claims

Include people who have not petitioned. Use states such as unresolved, deceased before cutoff, personally relinquished, eligible but lower priority, or selected.

Person / former name	Descent and place	Status at cutoff	Rule + exhibit

Which claim currently appears strongest, and what evidence could overturn it?

Your determination

1 / The successor

Name the person entitled to the entire estate at 6:15 a.m. on 20 September 1913. Include any former surname.

2 / The qualifying line

Give the chain from Gideon and cite the relationship and identity evidence.

3 / Priority and competing claims

Explain the position of each earlier person. Deal expressly with Peter Vale and Lawrence Ashcombe. Cite settlement clauses and exhibit fields.

4 / A final check

Identify the error in the old memorandum. Explain the household's zero-children entry. Name the next two people in the order after setting aside only your selected successor, then the next selected person, using the same cutoff facts.

Evidence and continuation

Continue your determination here. Cite the exhibit, the exact field and the clause it satisfies. Keep a separate note of any fact you could not establish.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

OPTIONAL HELP

Use one hint at a time.

Return to the records as soon as a hint gives you a next step. The original hint levels and exhibit references remain unchanged in this edition.

If a scene has made you certain about somebody, ask which record supports that certainty. Caring about a person, distrusting them, or finding their explanation plausible is not a substitute for a link in the evidence.

The story can leave a motive complicated while the record answers a factual question. You are allowed to reach a firm identification and still disagree about the person involved.

The following pages retain their original hint folios. Read progressively. Keep the separate sealed solution closed until you have committed your answer.

Hints / first nudge

Read only the question you are working on. The next file pages become more explicit.

Where do I start?

Compare E01's rules with the words used by the petitioners in E03. Does the settlement rank names, men, living generations, or branches?

Whose branch comes first?

Use E02 for Gideon's children and E04-E05 for the family behind a changed surname. Mark the order before you cross out anyone.

Is the old memorandum trustworthy?

E09 distinguishes a copied index from full particulars. Ask what the index actually proves and what it omits.

A person seems to disappear

Search the archive index for records that retain a birth date, parent or employee number across a surname change.

What does the relinquishment do?

Separate the signer's position from the position of a descendant. Read R5 and the exact language of E08.

Can I finish with a name?

Your proof needs identity, descent, survival at the cutoff, and priority. E16 tells you what the inquiry can treat as complete.

Hints / compare these records

Branch order

Frances was born before Matthew. Her marriage changes the surname in her records, not her place among Gideon's children. Within her family, compare the two birth dates in E05.

The apparent death

Compare E10 with E11: father, mother's former surname, birthplace and birth date. The age and name in a death index are not the whole identity.

The later surname

E12 has an original engagement and an amendment. Follow its employee number into E15. Use E13 to verify the mother's remarriage.

The census

E14's zero counts apply to the present marriage. A relationship-to-head label does not undo the parentage in a birth record.

The second and third places

After resolving the elder child's branch, consider Alice. Her personal relinquishment requires another step within her branch before returning to Matthew's family.

Hints / the last step

The child in the index

D-447 belongs to Walter and Jane Bell's child. B-903 belongs to Robert and Edith Bell's child. They are different children.

Identity and survival

The service file joins Ada Bell to Ada Finch; the mother, birth date and continuing employee number support the link. E15 places that employee in the house at the required instant.

Priority

Trace Gideon to Frances, then Robert, then the child in B-903. R4 preserves a dead ancestor's branch. Compare that route with Alice's and Matthew's branches.

The next places

Alice is alive but personally relinquished. Her son retains his place under R5. Once Frances's branch is complete, Matthew's elder child is next.

Write your own cited determination before opening the solution. The solution will explain the complete order and the limits of each record.

SEALED SOLUTION

Stop here until you commit.

This file reveals the investigation, the identities, and the ending. Keep it separate from the player packet.

Before continuing, write your conclusion, cite the records that support it, and name an uncertainty the file does not resolve.

Read the evidence-cited solution first. The expanded aftermath follows the original ending. It develops the human consequences; it does not supply a clue needed to solve the case.

A blank reverse follows this cover so the first answer starts on a fresh sheet when this file is printed on both sides.

SPOILER BARRIER

The answer is overleaf.

Keep this file closed until your written reconstruction is complete.

The rightful successor

Ada Finch, born Ada Bell on 5 March 1888, is entitled to the entire Ashcombe Estate at 6:15 a.m. on 20 September 1913.

Her qualifying descent is **Gideon Ashcombe → Frances Ashcombe (Bell) → Robert Bell → Ada Bell (Finch)**.

Frances is Gideon's eldest child. Her elder child is Robert. Robert's only child is Ada. Frances and Robert died before the cutoff; R4 preserves the priority of their branch. Ada was living at the required instant and has filed no relinquishment. R8 selects her before the inquiry ever reaches Alice Vale or Matthew's branch.

The order among the eligible living people

Place	Person	Reason
1	Ada Finch	Senior branch: Frances → Robert
2	Peter Vale	Frances → Alice; Alice relinquished personally
3	Lawrence Ashcombe	Matthew's elder child
4	Celia Marsh	Matthew's younger child

Alice Vale is living but is not eligible to receive the estate because E08 is effective under R5. She is bypassed personally; Peter keeps his branch's priority. The rank list sets aside earlier selected people using the same cutoff facts. It predicts no future transfer.

The central mistake

The dead infant in D-447 is not Robert's daughter. An unfinished index comparison became a claim that an entire branch had ended. Ada's later use of Finch helped that mistaken conclusion persist.

Prove the identity and descent

Required link	Visible proof
Gideon → Frances	E02: Frances born 18 February 1832, child of Gideon. E04: bride Frances Ashcombe names father Gideon and marries Nathan Bell.
Frances → Robert	E05 B-112: Robert born 14 January 1855; parents Nathan Bell and Frances formerly Ashcombe. E04 supports the household continuity.
Robert → Ada Bell	E10 B-903: Ada born 5 March 1888 at 4 Mill Lane; parents Robert Bell and Edith formerly Lane. E06 links Robert to the same wife and household.
Ada Bell → Ada Finch	E12: unchanged birth date, parent particulars, signed surname amendment and continuing employee number 27. E13 confirms Edith's remarriage to Samuel Finch and the date that prompted the amendment.
Alive at the cutoff	E15: the housekeeper saw Ada Finch, employee 27, at the linen-room table at 6:15 a.m. on 20 September. The later signed wage receipt corroborates continuing life.
No personal exclusion	E16: E08 is the only registered relinquishment, and no other exclusion applies. Ada is not its signer.

The records join through multiple particulars. A shared name alone would not establish this route. R2 recognizes the recorded descent, R6 permits supported identity across surnames, and R4 requires survival at the specified instant.

Resolve every superior position

Position examined	Disposition and support
Gideon / root	Not a candidate under R2; begin with his children.
Frances / eldest child	Born 1832, before Matthew (1835) and Julian (1841), E02. Died 1899. Bypass her personally under R4 and remain in her branch.
Robert / Frances's elder child	Born 1855, before Alice (1858), E05. Died 1904, E06. Bypass him personally under R4 and examine his child.
Ada / Robert's child	One child, B-903, under E16; identity and survival proved in E10, E12-E15. Select under R8. No earlier descendant remains unresolved.
Alice / Frances's younger child	Living under E16, but personal relinquishment E08 predates cutoff. R5 preserves her son's priority.
Peter / Alice's child	E07 proves descent; E16 proves life and sole-child scope. He follows Ada when Ada alone is set aside.
Matthew's branch	E02 places it after Frances's entire branch. Matthew died in 1905. Lawrence (1863) precedes Celia (1868). E16 closes their issue.
Julian's branch	Last child of Gideon; outgoing holder and deceased, with no children, E02/E16.

E16 certifies complete branch counts, no extra children and the complete relinquishment register. It deliberately leaves the B-903/D-447 identity comparison to the player. Its completeness is a stated fictional case fact under R7, not an inference from census omissions or the petitioners' shortlist.

Why the rival readings fail

Peter's claim

Peter correctly identifies Frances as the senior branch and correctly preserves his own place after Alice's personal relinquishment. His decisive error is treating the copied death-index line as Robert's child. Robert's branch has priority over Alice's, and Ada survives within it.

The two Ada Bells

Particular	B-903 / rightful line	D-447 / deceased child
Birth	5 March 1888	12 February 1888 (linked B-891)
Place	4 Mill Lane, Millford	9 Harbour Street, Bracken
Father	Robert Bell / joiner	Walter Bell / dock labourer
Mother	Edith, formerly Lane	Jane, formerly Pike

E12 also positively records Robert and Edith's daughter in service in 1905, long after the other child's death. The mistake is demonstrable; the player need not assume that every death record is wrong.

Lawrence's claim

Lawrence has a genuine qualifying relationship through Matthew. R2 imposes no sex or surname restriction, however, and R3 completes Frances's elder branch before Matthew's. He is eligible but lower in priority.

The household return

E14 says Edith had no children in her present marriage to Samuel. That does not deny her child from her earlier marriage to Robert. The recorded word Daughter describes Ada's household relationship to Samuel, not a new parentage that extinguishes the birth-record relationship.

An acceptable answer

Award the case on the quality of the cited proof, not an exact wording match. A correct name without the identity bridge, branch priority and competing-claim analysis is an incomplete determination.

The door she used

Harcourt found Ada at the linen-room table, folding a sheet along a seam she had repaired herself. He had rehearsed his announcement in the corridor. It sounded absurd beside the practical business of a house that still needed putting in order.

| *There is a matter concerning your father, Miss Finch.*

She looked up. Most people in the house meant Samuel when they said her father. Harcourt put a copy of the birth entry on the table and waited until she had read Robert's name.

Her mother had kept Bell for three years after the funeral. Finch had come later, with a smaller cottage, a steadier wage and a man who never made either of them feel borrowed. Ada had changed the name in the wage book because the housekeeper asked which name to write. She had not understood that anyone might lose her in the change.

Harcourt explained the settlement. He explained the branches and the dead child with the same name. When he reached the unfinished memorandum, Ada read its final pencilled instruction twice.

| *He knew he had not checked it.*

Harcourt did not defend the sentence. He placed the determination beside it.

At the front of the house Lawrence and Peter waited in the drawing room. Ada had entered that room hundreds of times with folded linen or a message. This time Harcourt asked whether she would like him to speak first.

She shook her head, took the keys, and went through the door she had always been told to leave closed.

Author's note

This ending supplies an imagined response after the proved result. It adds no fact required to solve the case. The investigation ends with the evidence-backed determination on the preceding pages.

AFTER THE CASE

The question after the front door

After the original solution and continuation

After Ada entered by the front door, there was a silence in which everyone seemed to expect her to become a different kind of person.

She remained Ada Finch. She knew where the linen was kept and which passages led most quickly through the house. She did not suddenly know how to supervise a fund or distinguish useful advice from an attempt to take over her decisions.

Harcourt set the determination before her. Gideon, Frances, Robert, Ada. The first surviving eligible person in the eldest branch, alive at the fixed instant. Peter followed her; Lawrence and Celia came after him. Alice's registered act excluded Alice personally. It had not erased her son. Ada's changed surname had not erased Robert's child.

"I should like to read it myself," Ada said.

"Of course."

She heard the ease of that reply and wondered how much of it depended on what the determination had just made her. Agnes had respected her signature on the payroll before anyone followed it toward a settlement. Ada did not intend to forget the difference.

Celia waited while she read. Lawrence had questions about management. Peter had questions about the old note. They were questions someone would eventually need to address, but neither was permission to speak first for Ada.

"In a moment," she told them.

Peter looked at the memorandum. "I believed it."

Ada had no evidence requiring her to call that a lie. She also did not have to make him comfortable with the effect of believing it.

"You used it to say the line had ended."

He nodded. There was no quick repair available in the room.

Celia asked whether Ada wanted a chair nearer the window. Ada accepted. It was an offer she could answer without surrendering the rest of the conversation. Of the people who had hoped to inherit, Celia was the one giving her that much space.

The house would not become fair merely because a servant had been correctly identified as its successor. Wages, work, and dependence did not vanish at the front door. Ada had inherited the property under a fictional settlement, not proof that she would manage every part of it wisely.

She finished reading and asked Harcourt to show her what she would next be responsible for. Then she asked Agnes to sit down while they discussed it.